"God is punishing me with this illness."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Many have heard that sickness is God's punishment, or they search their past for what they did wrong. Guilt over past sins can attach itself to a diagnosis.

What Scripture teaches

When Jesus' disciples asked about a man born blind, "Who sinned, this man or his parents?" Jesus answered, "Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him." Job's friends insisted that his suffering was punishment, and God said they were wrong. "For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust." Christ bore our sins on the cross: "Surely He took on our infirmities and carried our sorrows." For the believer, the punishment has been borne. Illness is part of living in a fallen world.

> *"Jesus answered, 'Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him.'"* (John 9:3).

Also see

> "Surely He took on our infirmities and carried our sorrows; yet we considered Him stricken by God, struck down and afflicted" (Isaiah 53:4).

> "For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust" (Psalm 103:14).

> "After the LORD had spoken these words to Job, He said to Eliphaz the Temanite, 'My wrath is kindled against you and your two friends. For you have not spoken about Me accurately, as My servant Job has.'" (Job 42:7).

> "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus" (Romans 8:1).

Common self-statements

- I deserve this.
- God is angry at me.
- This is payback.
- I must have sinned.
- God is teaching me a lesson.
- My past caught up with me.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing God either blesses with health or punishes with illness.
- Fortune telling: Predicting more punishment.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that God is punishing me.
- Personalization: Calling myself punished.

Challenging questions

- What makes me think this is punishment?
- How did Jesus answer the question about the blind man?

- What does the cross say about my sin?
- Do I know faithful people who suffered illness?
- What sin, if any, should I bring to God for forgiveness, and is it the cause?
- What does God say about me now?

Truth summary

> Illness is not God's punishment for me. Christ carried my sin and sorrows. God is with me in suffering and can display His works even in illness.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Sickness
- Guilt/Shame
- Suffering
- Grace
- God, All Loving

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Love
- Divorce

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "God is punishing me with this illness"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"God is punishing me with this illness." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What makes me think this is punishment?
- ☐ How did Jesus answer the question about the blind man?
- ☐ What does the cross say about my sin?
- ☐ Do I know faithful people who suffered illness?
- ☐ What sin, if any, should I bring to God for forgiveness, and is it the cause?
- ☐ What does God say about me now?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Not all suffering is punishment.
- ☐ Christ carried my sorrows.
- ☐ There is no condemnation in Christ.
- ☐ God knows my frame.
- ☐ God's works can be displayed in me.
- ☐ He is with me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ John 9:3
  "Jesus answered, 'Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him.'"
- ☐ Isaiah 53:4
  "Surely He took on our infirmities and carried our sorrows; yet we considered Him stricken by God, struck down and afflicted."
- ☐ Psalm 103:14
  "For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Not punished: Each week, note one reminder of God's grace.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, John 9:3 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Christ carried my sorrows, and there is no condemnation for me.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Sickness" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

These cards support emotional and spiritual care and do not replace medical care. Follow your doctor's advice about treatment and medication, and choose steps that are safe for your body. In an emergency call 911; for thoughts of self-harm call or text 988 (U.S.).

- [ ] Examine the belief. Write why you think it is punishment.
- [ ] Confess and receive forgiveness. Bring any sin to God.
- [ ] Read John 9:1–3. Notice Jesus' answer.
- [ ] Share. Talk with a pastor or counselor.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "God is punishing me with this illness": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Not punished
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~God is punishing me with this illness.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I fear You are punishing me. Thank You that Christ bore my sin. Comfort me in this illness and show Your love. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

“I must have done something to deserve this.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

The mind seeks explanations for pain, and self-blame can feel easier than randomness. Rumination about past mistakes fuels shame.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus said of those killed in a tragedy, that they were not worse sinners than others (Luke 13:1–5). He said of the blind man, “Neither this man nor his parents sinned.” “The soul who sins is the one who will die,” yet “A son will not bear the iniquity of his father.” Suffering in a fallen world often comes without a proportionate cause. Believers may repent of sin and be forgiven, but suffering is not a ledger of what we deserve.

> *“Jesus answered, ‘Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him.’”* (John 9:3).

Also see

> “The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him” (Ezekiel 18:20).

> “Or those eighteen who were killed when the tower of Siloam collapsed on them: Do you think that they were more sinful than all the others living in Jerusalem?” (Luke 13:4).

> “Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” (Romans 8:1).

> “For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust” (Psalm 103:14).

Common self-statements

- It is my fault.
- If I had been better, this would not have happened.
- This is what I get.
- I deserve to suffer.
- I brought it on myself.
- God is balancing the scales.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing suffering is either deserved or random.
- Fortune telling: Predicting more consequences.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that I deserve it.
- Personalization: Calling myself deserving of suffering.

Challenging questions

- What specifically do I think I did?
- Would I say a friend deserved the same illness?

- What did Jesus say about suffering and sin?
- What has been forgiven and what do I carry?
- What caused my illness according to my doctors?
- How can I put down self-blame?

Truth summary

> My suffering is not a measure of what I deserve. Jesus rejects the simple equation between suffering and sin. I can bring real sin to God for forgiveness and let go of self-blame.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Guilt/Shame
- Suffering
- Sickness
- Forgiveness
- Grace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Love
- Divorce

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must have done something to deserve this"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must have done something to deserve this." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What specifically do I think I did?
- ☐ Would I say a friend deserved the same illness?
- ☐ What did Jesus say about suffering and sin?
- ☐ What has been forgiven and what do I carry?
- ☐ What caused my illness according to my doctors?
- ☐ How can I put down self-blame?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Suffering is not always deserved.
- ☐ Jesus rejects the equation.
- ☐ I am forgiven in Christ.
- ☐ God knows my frame.
- ☐ I can put down self-blame.
- ☐ He is with me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ John 9:3
  "Jesus answered, 'Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him.'"
- ☐ Ezekiel 18:20
  "The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him."
- ☐ Luke 13:4
  "Or those eighteen who were killed when the tower of Siloam collapsed on them: Do you think that they were more sinful than all the others living in Jerusalem?"

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Self-blame lifted: Each week, note one thought of self-blame you replaced.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, John 9:3 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Jesus rejects the simple link between suffering and sin.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Guilt/Shame" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

These cards support emotional and spiritual care and do not replace medical care. Follow your doctor's advice about treatment and medication, and choose steps that are safe for your body. In an emergency call 911; for thoughts of self-harm call or text 988 (U.S.).

- ☐ Write the charge. State what you blame yourself for.
- ☐ Speak to yourself as to a friend. Rewrite it kindly.
- ☐ Confess if needed. Receive forgiveness.
- ☐ Talk with a counselor. Work through guilt.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must have done something to deserve this": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Self-blame lifted
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must have done something to deserve this.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I search my past for a reason. Free me from false guilt, forgive what is real, and comfort me in my suffering. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

“A loving God wouldn't let me suffer like this.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Pain makes God’s love hard to see. If He is all-powerful and loving, the logic seems to say He would stop it. Many faithful people have struggled with this tension.

What Scripture teaches

“My thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways My ways.” Habakkuk, Job, and the psalmists asked why. “Why, O LORD, do You stand far off?” God’s love is shown most clearly in the cross: “God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.” “We do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses.” Not all questions have answers now, but God is with you, and suffering does not disprove love.

> *“But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us”* (Romans 5:8).

Also see

> “‘For My thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways My ways,’ declares the LORD. ‘For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so My ways are higher than your ways and My thoughts than your thoughts.’” (Isaiah 55:8–9).

> “Why, O LORD, do You stand far off? Why do You hide in times of trouble?” (Psalm 10:1).

> “For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who was tempted in every way that we are, yet was without sin” (Hebrews 4:15).

> “And we know that God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose” (Romans 8:28).

Common self-statements

- If God loved me, He would stop it.
- He could help but does not.
- Love would not let this happen.
- Either He is not loving or not powerful.
- God has turned away.
- I do not understand His love.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing God is either loving or lets me suffer.
- Fortune telling: Predicting continued pain without God.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling pain and concluding that God does not love me.
- Labeling: Calling God unloving.

Challenging questions

- What exactly do I feel God has done or failed to do?
- Where did the psalmists take such questions?

- What did God do about suffering at the cross?
- Who has shown me God's love in this?
- What can I know even if I do not understand?
- What would it look like to bring this honestly to God?

Truth summary

> Suffering does not prove that God does not love me. His love was shown at the cross. I can ask my hardest questions, and He can bear them. I can trust Him even without all the answers.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Suffering
- God, All Loving
- Faith
- Hardship
- Hopeless

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Divorce
- Forgive/Forgiveness

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "A loving God wouldn't let me suffer like this"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"A loving God wouldn't let me suffer like this." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What exactly do I feel God has done or failed to do?
- ☐ Where did the psalmists take such questions?
- ☐ What did God do about suffering at the cross?
- ☐ Who has shown me God's love in this?
- ☐ What can I know even if I do not understand?
- ☐ What would it look like to bring this honestly to God?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God proved His love at the cross.
- ☐ Jesus sympathizes with my weakness.
- ☐ His ways are higher than mine.
- ☐ I can ask honest questions.
- ☐ He works for good.
- ☐ He is with me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Romans 5:8
  "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."
- ☐ Isaiah 55:8–9
  "'For My thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways My ways,' declares the LORD. 'For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so My ways are higher than your ways and My thoughts than your thoughts.'"
- ☐ Psalm 10:1
  "Why, O LORD, do You stand far off? Why do You hide in times of trouble?"

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Honest with God: Each week, write one honest prayer.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 5:8 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God proved His love for me at the cross.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Suffering" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

These cards support emotional and spiritual care and do not replace medical care. Follow your doctor's advice about treatment and medication, and choose steps that are safe for your body. In an emergency call 911; for thoughts of self-harm call or text 988 (U.S.).

- [ ] Write your question. Tell God exactly what you think.
- [ ] Read Psalm 13 and 88. Notice the honesty.
- [ ] Talk to a pastor or friend. Share the struggle.
- [ ] Remember the cross. Read Romans 5:8 daily.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "A loving God wouldn't let me suffer like this": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Honest with God
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~A loving God wouldn't let me suffer like this.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I do not understand why. Hear my honest questions, show me Your love, and hold me until I see more. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

“God has abandoned me.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

In long illness, prayers can feel unanswered and God silent. Loneliness and pain make His presence hard to sense.

What Scripture teaches

“Why, O LORD, do You stand far off?” the psalmist asks. And yet: “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted.” “When you pass through the waters, I will be with you.” Hebrews records God’s promise, “Never will I leave you, never will I forsake you” (Hebrews 13:5). Feelings of abandonment are real, and they are not the final word. Even Jesus on the cross cried out, “My God, My God, why have You forsaken Me?” (Psalm 22:1). God understands the sense of abandonment, and He has not left you.

> *“When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; and when you go through the rivers, they will not overwhelm you. When you walk through the fire, you will not be scorched; the flames will not set you ablaze”* (Isaiah 43:2).

Also see

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “Why, O LORD, do You stand far off? Why do You hide in times of trouble?” (Psalm 10:1).

> “Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content with what you have, for God has said: ‘Never will I leave you, never will I forsake you.’” (Hebrews 13:5).

> “Yet I am always with You; You hold my right hand” (Psalm 73:23).

Common self-statements

- God has left me.
- He is silent because He is gone.
- I am on my own.
- He does not care.
- My prayers go nowhere.
- I feel nothing.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing God is either felt or absent.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that God will never come near.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling alone and concluding that God is gone.
- Emotional reasoning: Calling myself abandoned.

Challenging questions

- When have I felt God near before?
- Who has shown up for me in this illness?
- What does Scripture promise about God’s presence in hardship?

- What did the psalmists do with feelings of abandonment?
- How might God be present in ways I do not feel?
- What small act of trust could I take?

Truth summary

> Feeling abandoned is not the same as being abandoned. God promises to be with me through the waters. I can cry out honestly, look for His presence in people and Scripture, and trust Him.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Suffering
- Loneliness
- God, All Knowing
- Faith
- Trust

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Forgive/Forgiveness
- Divorce

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

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God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "God has abandoned me"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"God has abandoned me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When have I felt God near before?
- ☐ Who has shown up for me in this illness?
- ☐ What does Scripture promise about God's presence in hardship?
- ☐ What did the psalmists do with feelings of abandonment?
- ☐ How might God be present in ways I do not feel?
- ☐ What small act of trust could I take?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God is with me through the waters.
- ☐ He is near to the brokenhearted.
- ☐ He will never leave me.
- ☐ I can cry out honestly.
- ☐ Feelings are not facts.
- ☐ He holds my right hand.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Isaiah 43:2
  "When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; and when you go through the rivers, they will not overwhelm you. When you walk through the fire, you will not be scorched; the flames will not set you ablaze."
- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."
- ☐ Psalm 10:1
  "Why, O LORD, do You stand far off? Why do You hide in times of trouble?"

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Signs of presence: Each week, note one sign of God's presence or care.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Isaiah 43:2 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I will not be abandoned; God is with me through the waters.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Suffering" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

These cards support emotional and spiritual care and do not replace medical care. Follow your doctor's advice about treatment and medication, and choose steps that are safe for your body. In an emergency call 911; for thoughts of self-harm call or text 988 (U.S.).

- [ ] Cry out. Pray Psalm 13 or 22.
- [ ] Look for signs. Note kindness, provision, and peace.
- [ ] Stay with Scripture. Read a short psalm daily.
- [ ] Reach out. Tell a friend or pastor.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "God has abandoned me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Signs of presence
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~God has abandoned me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I feel abandoned. Draw near, hold my hand, and let me know You are here. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

"My suffering is meaningless."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Pain without explanation can feel pointless, and nothing seems to come from it. The inability to see any good makes it worse.

What Scripture teaches

"We also rejoice in our sufferings, because we know that suffering produces perseverance; perseverance, character; and character, hope." "We know that God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose." "After you have suffered for a little while, the God of all grace… will Himself restore you, secure you, strengthen you, and establish you." We may not see the reason now, but meaning can be found: comfort for others, deeper trust, and hope of restoration. "So we fix our eyes not on what is seen, but on what is unseen."

> *"Not only that, but we also rejoice in our sufferings, because we know that suffering produces perseverance; perseverance, character; and character, hope. And hope does not disappoint us, because God has poured out His love into our hearts through the Holy Spirit, whom He has given us"* (Romans 5:3–5).

Also see

> "And we know that God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose" (Romans 8:28).

> "And after you have suffered for a little while, the God of all grace, who has called you to His eternal glory in Christ, will Himself restore you, secure you, strengthen you, and establish you" (1 Peter 5:10).

> "So we fix our eyes not on what is seen, but on what is unseen. For what is seen is temporary, but what is unseen is eternal" (2 Corinthians 4:18).

> "Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of compassion and the God of all comfort, who comforts us in all our troubles, so that we can comfort those in any trouble with the comfort we ourselves have received from God" (2 Corinthians 1:3–4).

Common self-statements

- It is all for nothing.
- There is no point.
- I get nothing out of this.
- God wastes my pain.
- No good will come.
- It is senseless.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing suffering is either useful or meaningless.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that no good will come.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling pain and concluding that it is pointless.
- Labeling: Calling my suffering meaningless.

Challenging questions

- What have I learned or become through this, even small things?
- Whom has my suffering made me more sensitive to?
- What does Scripture say about God's purposes?
- What good could God bring, even if I cannot see it?
- What would it mean to wait for meaning?
- How could I use what I am learning to help someone?

Truth summary

> God can bring meaning from suffering, and nothing is wasted in His hands. I may not see it now, but I can look for growth, comfort for others, and hope of restoration.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Suffering
- Hardship
- Hopeless
- Faith
- Will of God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Forgive/Forgiveness
- Divorce

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My suffering is meaningless"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My suffering is meaningless." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What have I learned or become through this, even small things?
- ☐ Whom has my suffering made me more sensitive to?
- ☐ What does Scripture say about God's purposes?
- ☐ What good could God bring, even if I cannot see it?
- ☐ What would it mean to wait for meaning?
- ☐ How could I use what I am learning to help someone?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Suffering produces perseverance and hope.
- ☐ God works all things for good.
- ☐ God will restore me.
- ☐ He comforts me so I can comfort others.
- ☐ Nothing is wasted.
- ☐ Hope does not disappoint.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Romans 5:3–5**
  "Not only that, but we also rejoice in our sufferings, because we know that suffering produces perseverance; perseverance, character; and character, hope. And hope does not disappoint us, because God has poured out His love into our hearts through the Holy Spirit, whom He has given us."
- ☐ **Romans 8:28**
  "And we know that God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose."
- ☐ **1 Peter 5:10**
  "And after you have suffered for a little while, the God of all grace, who has called you to His eternal glory in Christ, will Himself restore you, secure you, strengthen you, and establish you."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

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PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Meaning found: Each month, note one thing suffering has taught you.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 5:3–5 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Suffering produces perseverance, character, and hope.""
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- [ ] List what you learned. Write the changes in you.
- [ ] Comfort someone. Use your experience to encourage another.
- [ ] Wait with hope. Read Romans 5:3–5 daily.
- [ ] Talk with a pastor. Explore meaning together.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

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What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My suffering is meaningless": _____ % My truth: _____ %

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My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My suffering is meaningless.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I cannot see the meaning in this. Bring good from my pain, use me to comfort others, and hold me in hope. Amen.

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